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FIND OUT WHAT THE JOB EXPECTS BEFORE YOU APPLY

# Program or Technical Program Manager?

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A technical program manager does program-management work with an added expectation: understanding the technical work well enough to help teams plan and deliver it.

That doesn't make the other role easier. A training program, a hospital process change, and a software launch need different experience. Start with the kind of work you want to run, then check what the opening requires.

## 1 Ask what the program is meant to change

A program manager coordinates related work toward an outcome. That can include setting goals, arranging resources, resolving dependencies, and checking whether the changes produced the intended result.

A technical program manager does that work for a technical program. Along with the schedule and people, they need to understand the systems involved, how those systems depend on each other, and which technical decisions affect delivery.

### EXAMPLE

Imagine a company launching a service in another country. A program manager might coordinate training, customer support, legal approvals, and the launch plan. A technical program manager might coordinate the billing, identity, and data changes needed for the service to work there.

Ask the hiring manager, "What would I be responsible for delivering, and how would you know the program had succeeded?"

## 2 Get an example of the technical depth

Don't assume the title tells you how much engineering knowledge you need. Some roles ask you to participate in design reviews. Others may expect you to read code, understand hardware, or investigate failures with engineers.

An opening titled Program Manager can include technical responsibilities too. Look at the requirements and the interview process before deciding you're qualified or ruling yourself out.

### EXAMPLE

"What technical decisions would I make myself? Could you give me an example of a problem the last person in this role had to work through?"

Amazon's Global Product Expansion technical program posting names technical dependencies, tradeoffs, and evaluating system-level designs. Its Learning and Development program posting asks for learning objectives, program delivery, and measuring training effectiveness. Both need subject knowledge, but you would prepare different examples for those interviews.

### 3 Compare the compensation without assuming a raise

The Levels.fyi US snapshot captured on September 5, 2026 shows:

Technical Program Manager: \$182,000 to \$310,000 at the 25th to 75th percentiles. Median total compensation: \$240,000. 90th percentile: \$400,000.

Program Manager: \$146,000 to \$235,000 at the 25th to 75th percentiles. Median total compensation: \$182,000. 90th percentile: \$301,000.

The two medians are \$58,000 apart. Those ranges cover the middle half of reported compensation, including base salary, stock, and bonus. They aren't minimum salaries or career limits.

These tech-focused datasets combine different employers, locations, and levels. They don't show what the same person would earn in both jobs. Don't apply the technology-sector range to a hospital or education role without checking its own pay information.

#### EXAMPLE

"What's the range for this level in my location? How much is base salary, how much is stock, and what determines the bonus?"

Write down the answers for the openings you're considering. You can compare actual offers without assuming that the higher-paying title guarantees more money.

### 4 Choose a kind of work you want to learn

Program management gives you options across functions such as operations, training, finance, and customer programs. Technical programs can involve software, hardware, infrastructure, security, or other engineering work.

Neither list is exclusive. A role at a technology company may focus on employee training, and a role at a healthcare organization may involve technical systems. The program's responsibilities matter more than the employer's industry label.

#### EXAMPLE

"Which teams would I work with each week, and what knowledge would you expect me to bring on day one?"

Compare their answer with a project you've worked on. If there's a gap, you can ask whether the team expects you to learn that part after joining.

### 5 Check the next level at that company

Technical program roles can progress to senior, principal, and director positions. Program managers can move into senior roles, portfolio leadership, or managing a program team.

Those are possible routes, not a fixed promotion sequence. A principal role may mean larger technical responsibility without direct reports. Managing a team involves hiring, feedback, and developing people, which is different work.

## EXAMPLE

"Can I keep progressing here without becoming a people manager? What would I need to demonstrate to move to the next level?"

Ask for an example of someone who has made that move. You'll have a clearer picture of the responsibilities that come with the title.

## 6 Prepare evidence from one project

Pick a project you can explain without inventing details. Start with the goal, your responsibility, the teams involved, and a decision you made.

For a program role, explain how you dealt with competing priorities, limited resources, or a change to the plan. For a technical program role, add the systems involved and explain a technical dependency or decision in enough detail for an engineer to question it.

## EXAMPLE

Instead of stopping at "I coordinated the launch," explain what you coordinated: "The support team needed training before rollout. I worked with the launch owner to change the sequence so training could finish first." Use the details of your own project, not this example as a claim about yours.

Before applying, fill this in:

- ☐ The program's goal:
- ☐ The decisions I would own:
- ☐ The teams I would work with:
- ☐ The systems or subject knowledge required:
- ☐ A project that shows my relevant experience:
- ☐ The experience I still need:
- ☐ The pay range, level, and promotion requirements:

Take the unanswered items into the recruiter conversation. Ask about them before spending the interview trying to demonstrate skills the role doesn't require.

Salary sources: Levels.fyi US role pages, captured September 5, 2026. Recheck current figures before using them in a negotiation.

<https://www.levels.fyi/t/technical-program-manager?countryId=254>

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Role examples: Amazon Jobs 3008762, Technical Program Manager, Global Product Expansion, and 2910116, Learning and Development Program Manager, GES L&TD. Responsibilities can vary between employers. Scenarios and dialogue in this guide are illustrative, not accounts of Dennis's work.